

Disinformation Decoder

Anti-abortion politicians and activists use lies and confusion to manipulate people into accepting their unpopular agenda.

In the wake of the U.S. Supreme Court decision to end the federal constitutional right to abortion, [one in three women](#) no longer has [access to abortion](#) where they live. One in four states has [banned abortion](#) altogether. A sham lawsuit awaiting further consideration by the Supreme Court could affect [access to one method of medication abortion](#) across the country.

People in the United States want to make their own reproductive health decisions. [85% of Americans](#) want abortion to be legal. Well-aware of these truths, anti-abortion politicians mislead and confuse people to advance their agenda — relying on propaganda to deny the consequences of their laws and proposals, and sowing fear and uncertainty to cloak their attacks on our health and rights.

It's wrong, and it's insulting. But we don't have to be fooled. Use this resource to expose and defeat their sneaky language.

“Abortifacient”

Decoded: Technically this means something that causes an abortion. But anti-abortion activists are usually also anti-birth control — so those activists manipulate this term to mean anything that prevents a person from having a baby, including birth control.

An abortifacient is a drug, like the [abortion pill](#), that ends a pregnancy. Pregnancy happens after a fertilized egg implants in the uterus.

Abortifacients are not birth control. Birth control prevents pregnancy from happening in the first place.

Deception: Anti-reproductive health politicians and judges conflate birth control with abortion so they can restrict access to both.

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For example, anti-abortion politician Brenna Byrd, the attorney general of Iowa, cut off payment of public financial aid to sexual assault survivors who want abortions, questioning “whether [that] is an appropriate use of public funds” — but also cut off aid for [survivors’ purchases of emergency contraception](#), which is birth control.

“Abortion Reversal”

Decoded: Abortions cannot be “reversed.”

Medication abortion (aka the “[abortion pill](#)”) is a safe, effective way to end an early pregnancy. “Abortion pill” is the common name for two different medicines used for a medication abortion: mifepristone and misoprostol. Mifepristone stops a pregnancy from growing by blocking your body’s progesterone, which a pregnancy needs to grow. Then misoprostol causes cramping and bleeding to empty the uterus.

Deception: Anti-abortion politicians push the idea of replacing misoprostol with a large dose of progesterone to stop an abortion, even though [no medical evidence](#) suggests that’s safe or even possible. It could even [lead to serious health risks](#). Doctors and other medical experts say encouraging patients to replace misoprostol with progesterone is [unethical](#), [dangerous](#), and akin to experimenting on people like [guinea pigs](#).

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Policies [enacted in several states](#) and moving in [other legislatures](#) force doctors to tell patients that they can reverse a medication abortion if they change their mind. This is both factually and morally wrong.

Like forced waiting periods, these policies assume that the government must “help” people make their medical decisions. It interferes with trained health care providers’ expertise when doctors are required to use state-mandated scripts. It “solves” a nonexistent problem: that people change their minds in the middle of a medication abortion. ([They don’t.](#))

The real goals of promoting “abortion reversal” are to cause doubt among people who want safe, legal abortions, to [confuse the public](#) about the effectiveness of medication abortion, and to scare people away from it.

“Abortion Survivor” and “Born Alive” from “Attempted Abortion”

Decoded: Abortions end pregnancies.

The false narrative that “attempted” or “failed” abortion procedures later in pregnancy result in live births is not grounded in fact. [There’s no such thing as an “abortion survivor.”](#)

Deception: Abortion opponents like to equate safe, legal abortion with [infanticide](#) to portray abortion care as immoral (and illegal). Anti-abortion [legislation](#) that includes this language often criminalizes nurses and doctors who provide abortions later in pregnancy.

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“Born alive” legislation attempts to capitalize on [extremely rare](#) scenarios in which an abortion occurs later in pregnancy. Less than 1% of abortions occur later in pregnancy — most due to challenging circumstances in which a fetus develops a serious biological issue and/or a

pregnant person's health or life is in danger. People in these situations deserve compassion and support, not judgment.

Such legislation threatens doctors with prison under the absurd premise that they would respond to a live birth by committing infanticide. This is already illegal.

“Access to Birth Control Is Safe”

Decoded: Because opponents of abortion also oppose the constitutional right to privacy — which protects our access to birth control — more generally, access to birth control and other forms of sexual and reproductive health care is absolutely under threat.

Deception: Bans and restrictions on abortion don't just affect abortion. Anti-abortion activists are going after access to birth control, family-planning programs, STI testing, fertility treatments, and more. For example, [Students for Life](#) — an organization oft-cited in news coverage of efforts to ban abortion — labels birth control pills, hormonal patches, intrauterine devices, vaginal rings, and emergency contraception all as abortifacients that should be banned.

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- *In December, a federal judge in Texas [declared unlawful](#) the precedent that young people can confidentially get care through Title X, the nation's federal family planning program.*
- *[Tennessee](#) is set to reject federal HIV prevention funds in order to avoid giving grants to Planned Parenthood.*
- *[Florida](#) has moved to stop Planned Parenthood health centers from receiving state funds to provide STI and HIV testing, birth control, breast and cervical cancer screenings, and other health care.*

“Crisis Pregnancy Centers”

Decoded: Crisis Pregnancy Centers strive to stop people from getting abortions.

[“Crisis Pregnancy Centers”](#) (CPCs) are built and staffed to seem like legitimate reproductive health clinics and sex educators — but in fact, they devote themselves to scaring and shaming patients and communities. Their mission is to prevent people from having abortions or using birth control, and to shame them for having sex at all.

Deception: The purpose of CPCs is to scare and shame people out of having sex, using birth control, and having abortions.

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CPCs are often located [near Planned Parenthood health centers](#) and lure people in with deceptive advertising that implies they offer the same services as Planned Parenthood. In reality, CPCs are often not regulated and not licensed to provide medical services. Most don't

offer comprehensive care, but rather provide misleading, biased, and [medically inaccurate information](#) about abortion. CPC staff [harass, bully, and lie to visitors](#); [violate their confidentiality](#); and [threaten their health](#).

“Fetal Heartbeat”

Decoded: At six weeks, a pregnancy is in the embryonic stage of development. Embryos don’t have hearts at six weeks.

At six weeks of development, [electrical activity](#) can be detected in a part of the embryo. When ultrasound machines detect that signal, they [translate it into a sound](#) that can resemble a heartbeat — but the cells remain in the earliest phase of the process that leads to the development of a heart. *An embryo develops into a fetus after about [10 weeks](#), so the reference is medically incorrect.*

Deception: Anti-abortion politicians talk about “fetal heartbeats” to [justify six-week abortion bans](#) — which outlaw abortion before many people even know they’re pregnant.

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This emotionally loaded language paints a medically inaccurate picture of fetal development, intended to portray those who seek or provide safe, legal abortion as bad people. Politicians who back six-week bans would rather focus us on this fictional term than talk about the lives of the people who don’t want to be pregnant.

“Fetal Pain”

Decoded: No evidence for claims of “fetal pain” exists.

There is [no real way to detect or measure](#) “fetal pain” because perception in the womb — where the fetus grows in a [sedated](#) state — is different than what people experience in the world. *Scientific and medical consensus says a fetus does not develop the sensory structures needed to potentially perceive painful stimuli until the third trimester, starting at about [27 to 30 weeks](#) of pregnancy.*

Deception: Anti-abortion politicians and activists drummed up junk science about “fetal pain” to pass [20-week abortion bans](#). The leading organization for obstetricians and gynecologists [condemns the term](#) as “a misrepresentation of the science.” The phrase manipulates people into seeing abortions at 20 weeks as monstrous.

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When abortion is needed later in pregnancy, it’s typically in very complex circumstances — such as severe fetal anomalies and dire risks to the pregnant person’s health — where a pregnant person and their doctor need every medical option available to maximize health and safety and minimize unnecessary trauma.

“Infanticide”

Decoded: Infanticide is the crime of killing an infant after birth.

Infanticide and abortion are categorically and fundamentally different. Abortion is health care.

Deception: Anti-abortion politicians call abortions later in pregnancy “infanticide” to stir public outrage and horror. They demonize the people who seek abortions in order to make it easier to criminalize the nurses and doctors who provide their care — and to outlaw abortion altogether.

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Abortions later in pregnancy happen because of [challenging circumstances](#) — when the fetus has a serious biological issue and/or a pregnant person’s life or health is in danger. People and families in these situations face devastating decisions. They deserve compassion and support — not judgment, and certainly not politicians telling them what to do. SEE [“UNBORN”](#)

“Informed Consent”

Decoded: Nurses and doctors already give patients the info they need to make medical decisions.

Informed consent is incredibly important in health care. The term, as medical professionals use it, describes how providers tell patients about the risks, benefits, and alternatives that come with a course of treatment. Anti-abortion politicians and activists swipe the term “informed consent” to mislabel laws that command providers to swamp people seeking abortions with lies. The so-called “informed consent” scripts dictated by such laws are intended to shame and scare patients into changing their minds.

Deception: Anti-abortion “informed consent” laws imply that people seeking abortion arrive at their decisions without thinking, and need to be “educated.” By forcing doctors to lie to patients, however — requiring them to repeat, for example, myths that abortion is linked to breast cancer, harms fertility, and can lead to long-term negative mental health effects — politicians run roughshod over medical professionals’ ethical obligations, and breach the trust of patients who expect to hear truthful information about their health care.

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Politicians don’t belong in the exam room. Medical decisions are best left to patients and their health care providers. We must trust patients — including young people — to make their own decisions about their private health care and personal safety.

“Late-Term Abortion” and “Partial-Birth Abortion”

Decoded: These terms wrongly describe abortions later in pregnancy.

[Doctors reject](#) labels like “late-term abortion,” “partial birth abortion,” and “born alive” because they’re inflammatory rhetoric — specifically crafted to vilify abortions later in pregnancy.

As [Dr. Jen Gunter](#), an ob-gyn and abortion provider, wrote: “There are no ninth month abortions. Really. A ninth month abortion is a unicorn and so it’s ridiculous to even discuss it. Terminations after 24 weeks are for severe fetal anomalies.” The truth is that abortions later in pregnancy are extremely rare — only 1% of abortions occur after 21 weeks, and those abortions happen due to [very challenging circumstances](#).

Deception: Over the medical community’s objections, anti-abortion politicians have used these inflammatory buzzwords in legislation, at political rallies, and in televised government functions. *In the wake of the Supreme Court decision to end the federal constitutional right to abortion, opponents of abortion rights have invoked this inflammatory term in vain attempts to derail efforts to protect abortion rights in states like Michigan, Minnesota, and Nevada.*

Anti-abortion politicians use these terms to create a false perception of abortion later in pregnancy to stir up outrage against all safe, legal abortions.

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To make this rhetorical scare tactic even more desperate, anti-abortion politicians often use these terms to claim that without a specific law against it, doctors will help someone who decides to terminate a pregnancy while in labor. To repeat the basic truth: When abortion happens later in pregnancy, it’s when the fetus has a terminal biological issue and/or a pregnant person’s life or health is in danger.

“Let the States Regulate Abortion”

Decoded: People who want to ban abortion want it banned everywhere — period.

Deception: Politicians hostile to abortion have long claimed to want abortion access decided on a state-by-state basis. Shortly after the Supreme Court ended federal protection of the right to abortion, however, several anti-abortion members of Congress [introduced](#) a national abortion ban — undermining their claim that they wanted to give power to the states.

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In 2023, anti-abortion activists and organizations [sued the federal government](#) over its approval of mifepristone, one of two medicines used for decades in medication abortion in the U.S. If the suit succeeds, mifepristone could be banned nationwide — affecting access to medication abortion in every state.

“Never Medically Necessary”

Decoded: Abortions can be medically necessary.

Abortion can be medically necessary to save a pregnant person's life and safeguard their health. [Serious fetal anomalies and pregnancy complications](#) — such as amniotic sac rupture and infection, placental abruption, placenta accreta, and severe preeclampsia — do happen, particularly later in pregnancy. When bans stop pregnant people in these circumstances from getting abortions, death from blood loss, stroke, or septic shock can result. People [with cancer](#) or other chronic illnesses may also need an abortion to survive.

In addition, one of every 50 pregnancies are ectopic — when the embryo attaches outside the uterus. Usually detectable in the first trimester, [an ectopic pregnancy can become a medical emergency](#) if left untreated. And abortion medicines and procedures are often the safest way to [manage a miscarriage](#).

Deception: Anti-abortion politicians lie about the medical need for abortion to justify laws that place extreme restrictions on abortion or ban it outright. Since the loss of the federal constitutional right to abortion, pregnant people in states with bans have faced denials of care for [miscarriages](#), [ectopic pregnancies](#), [amniotic sac rupture](#), a [pre-cancerous molar pregnancy](#), and [other potentially fatal circumstances](#). [Proposals by anti-abortion politicians](#) to require doctors to “re-implant” an ectopic pregnancy into the uterus to “save” the embryo merely proposes an imaginary, [medically impossible procedure](#).

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Politicians who reject medically necessary abortions — particularly those [later in pregnancy](#) — threaten the lives of people in [complex health situations](#) who need every medical option available. Even anti-abortion laws with exceptions to save the pregnant person's life force doctors to let treatable conditions worsen until [lives are put at grave risk](#).

“Parents’ Rights”

Decoded: Anti-abortion and anti-sex education groups and politicians use the term “parents’ rights” to gain control over young people’s education and medical decisions.

While anti-abortion politicians continue to push for parental involvement laws, book bans, banning all kinds of education including sex education, and other abortion restrictions — including proposals to [imprison people who help minors](#) cross state lines to get legal abortions — some of the same lawmakers are banning gender-affirming care and proposing laws that threaten to take custody away from parents who seek this medically necessary, life-saving care for their own children. *Yet in Arkansas, the governor — anti-abortion politician Sarah Huckabee Sanders — signed a law in March 2023 to let companies employ 14-year-old children without parental consent.*

Deception: Anti-abortion groups and politicians aren’t concerned about children’s welfare or parents’ rights. They simply seek control over people’s lives and bodies.

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[embed tweet: https://twitter.com/scott_a_ross/status/1633554277288271873]

“Pro-Life”

Decoded: The “pro-life” label masks an agenda to control pregnant people’s bodies.

When the now-overturned 1973 [Roe v. Wade](#) ruling struck down state bans on abortion, anti-abortion activists and politicians mobilized under the “pro-life” banner. Through their votes and actions, however, such politicians have shown time and again that their agenda has nothing to do with the lives of pregnant people, their families, or anyone else. Their records show little concern for people who have unintended pregnancies or ectopic pregnancies, or who have died from unsafe and illegal procedures.

FULL PAGE INCLUDES ABOVE “DECODED,” BELOW “DECEPTION,” PLUS THE FOLLOWING BELOW “DECODED” INTRO:

Many abortion opponents who hide behind a “pro-life” label oppose [making health care affordable and accessible](#); oppose [life-saving vaccine requirements](#); oppose [social safety-net programs](#) for families with low incomes; oppose [gun-safety measures](#); support [capital punishment](#); and support the [deportation of immigrants](#) into dangerous and sometimes fatal situations. Activists who have [injured and murdered abortion providers](#) call themselves “pro-life.”

While giving [lip service to “women’s health”](#) — including stated concern for healthy pregnancies — politicians pushing abortion restrictions frequently do little to confront genuine, life-threatening public health challenges [such as maternal mortality](#), which disproportionately affects Black people and other people of color.

Meanwhile, even before the overturning of Roe, “pro-life” politicians enacted 6-week abortion bans in [Texas](#), [Georgia](#) and [Louisiana](#). These states all have worse-than-average maternal and infant mortality rates, have low rates of prenatal care access, and have significant shortages of ob-gyns.

Deception: Abortion bans put lives and health in danger. The “pro-life” label is a cheap and empty slogan — one crafted to all but shout that people who want abortion to be legal, [as 85% of Americans do](#), are heartless and murderous.

The “pro-life” label distracts from the harm that anti-abortion laws do — period.

“Selling Baby Parts”

Decoded: Nobody is selling fetal tissue from abortions.

Before 2015, Planned Parenthood sometimes offered abortion patients the [option to donate their fetal tissue](#) for medical research. *The Planned Parenthood health centers that provided this*

option received legal reimbursements for the costs — including work time — of transporting and preserving the tissue. But a [2015 smear campaign](#) made the false, outrageous, and dangerous accusation that Planned Parenthood was “selling baby parts.” The truth is that nobody sells fetal tissue.

Deception: In 2015, a group of anti-abortion extremists — who had close ties to people who have attempted to firebomb abortion clinics — conducted a propaganda campaign organized around deceptively edited smear videos. *These videos made false claims about patients who wanted to donate fetal tissue and about how Planned Parenthood handled those donations to medical research labs.* The videos were debunked. Planned Parenthood was cleared of all wrongdoing, and [won a judgment](#) against the perpetrators — who were [found liable of fraud and much more](#). But anti-abortion politicians and activists STILL invoke these falsified claims to justify calls to shut down Planned Parenthood health centers and block patients from care.

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This is [just one of many examples](#) of anti-abortion activists using doctored videos to attack Planned Parenthood.

“Unborn Baby”

Decoded: The word “baby” describes newborns and infants up to one year in age. The words “embryo” and “fetus” are medically accurate terms for what a pregnant person has in the womb.

Deception: The anti-abortion movement calls fertilized eggs and pregnancies “unborn babies” and “children” to present abortion as equivalent to infanticide or homicide. This is their core message, and they use this bogus equivalence to justify nearly all anti-abortion legislation.

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The “unborn baby” talking point stigmatizes abortion. It attempts to portray getting an abortion as criminal, morally wrong, or socially unacceptable — and lays the groundwork to interfere in pregnant people’s medical decisions. [Abortion stigma has real consequences](#).

Abortion is health care, and everyone deserves access to health care, including abortion.

SEE “INFANTICIDE”

“We Are Aborting Our Future”

Decoded: This is a way to allude to the so-called ‘Great Replacement’ — a white-nationalist conspiracy theory that inspired mass shooters in Buffalo, Pittsburgh, El Paso, and New Zealand.

Comments like this often come from [white nationalists](#) and extremists who fear that immigration and birth rate disparities are leading to the “replacement” of “our people.” *Anti-abortion extremists sometimes publicly admit to sharing this view.*

[embed: <https://twitter.com/HeartlandSignal/status/1646176955488673794> (text: “NE State Sen. Steve Erdman (R) uses Great Replacement talking points arguing for a six-week abortion ban. ... ‘[We have] not grown except those foreigners who have moved here or refugees who have been placed here ... because we’ve killed 200,000 people. These are people we killed.’”)]

Deception: Far-right extremists such as those responsible for the 2022 grocery-store shooting in Buffalo, the 2019 mosque shooting in Christchurch, New Zealand, and the 2018 synagogue shooting in Pittsburgh — and the apparent shooter in a 2019 massacre in El Paso — embrace a conspiracy theory known as “[the great replacement](#),” which *New York Times* columnist Farhad Manjoo described in 2019 as “a racist and misogynistic [notion] that holds that white people face existential decline, even extinction, because of rising immigration in the West and falling birth rates among white women (caused, of course, by feminism).”

Supporters of this racist conspiracy theory want to ban abortion because they suppose that taking pregnant people’s rights away will lead to the birth of more white babies. In a grim irony, anti-abortion policies tend to place their heaviest burdens on people who face systemic barriers to getting health care — who, in the United States, are disproportionately people of color.

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Politicians who embrace the “great replacement” theory, or who flirt with “great replacement” language as a way to appeal to people with racist views, have hailed abortion bans.

Matt Schlapp, an ally of former president Donald Trump who leads the high profile right-wing CPAC conference, expressed similar views after the leak of a draft of the Supreme Court decision in the case that overturned Roe:

[embed tweet:

https://twitter.com/justinbaragona/status/1527362753395994635?s=21&t=bvhHaWjtlWg_MV7S0T3NcA]

A shared desire to limit reproductive freedoms has spurred some anti-abortion activists to embrace ethnic-nationalist views — and vice versa. Former Rep. Steve King of Iowa, [once one of the most strident](#) anti-abortion politicians in Congress, received [praise from white nationalists for tweeting](#) his agreement with “great replacement” conspiracy theorists.

[embed screenshot of tweet: <https://twitter.com/RichardBSpencer/status/841074295925272578> (text: “The 15 Words: [C]ulture and demographics are our destiny. We can’t restore our civilization with somebody else’s babies.”)]

[Note: The mention of “15 Words” above amounts to a thinly veiled callout to a neo-Nazi slogan known as “[the 14 Words](#).”]